

German automakers in freefall

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【要点】

- ・ドイツの自動車大手3社（BMW、フォルクスワーゲン、メルセデス・ベンツ）は中国市場での販売減少により利益が大幅に低下し、これがヨーロッパと北米での好調さでも補えない状況にある。
- ・中国メーカーの欧州でのシェアが急速に拡大しており、2026年上半期の中国車のEU内販売は前年比63%増加し、全販売の約10%を占めるようになった。
- ・ドイツ自動車産業の危機は2035年のエンジン禁止令および産業促進法をめぐるEU機関の交渉と重なり、メーカーは排出ガス規制の緩和を求めるロビー活動を強化している。
- ・ドイツの極右政党「ドイツのための選択肢」がEUの排出ガス規制とドイツ産業保護の不十分さを批判する材料として、自動車セクターの雇用削減問題を政治利用している。

【メール原文】

Navigating the complex world of EU mobility policy and infrastructure. By JORDYN DAHL with TOMMASO LECCA and MARTINA SAPIO SNEAK PEEK — Job cuts across

Navigating the complex world of EU mobility policy and infrastructure.

By JORDYN DAHL

with TOMMASO LECCA and MARTINA SAPIO

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SNEAK PEEK

— Job cuts across the auto sector come as EU institutions negotiate future emission targets for the industry.

— Air France-KLM is in a race against Lufthansa over the future of TAP Air Portugal, the state-owned carrier set to be privatized.

— The EU's Foreign Subsidies Regulation is being credited with discouraging Chinese state-backed bids for strategic public contracts, including in the rail sector.

Good morning, and welcome to Morning Mobility. This newsletter will be on hiatus until Monday, Aug. 17. Have a great break.

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DRIVING THE DAY

CHINA CAUSES TROUBLE FOR GERMANY'S CARMAKERS: BMW was the final German automaker to report its financial results for the first half of the year and they were nearly as grim as for Volkswagen and Mercedes-Benz. The luxury automaker's pre-tax earnings fell 29 percent year-over-year, largely due to a fall in China sales.

Not an outlier: German automakers are all seeing their market share in China crumble. It's a sharp reversal for companies that made billions there over several decades. The three car firms are performing well in Europe and North America but it's not enough to make up for the drop in sales in their biggest market. But even their European base isn't safe. Faced with a slump at home, Chinese carmakers are boosting sales in Europe. Sales of Chinese cars in the EU surged 63 percent in the first half of this year, growing from 338,000 in 2025 to nearly 549,000 in 2026, according to car lobby ACEA. That's almost 10 percent of overall car sales.

How did it go so wrong? Jordyn has the story here .

Awkward timing: The automakers' troubles come as the EU institutions ramp up negotiations over the fate of the 2035 combustion engine ban and the Industrial Accelerator Act that will introduce European preference requirements. The industry's lobbyists have spent two years pushing for the EU to weaken its emissions targets, arguing that automakers will face fines that undermine their competitiveness.

Political impact: The far-right Alternative for Germany is seizing on the emission targets and the car sector's problems to attack the Berlin government for not doing enough to protect German industry. After Volkswagen announced it would be laying off 100,000 workers and shuttering factories, the AfD blamed the federal government and its "bitter battle against the internal combustion engine." German Chancellor Friedrich Merz and his coalition will get a first glimpse at how the cuts are playing out with voters in state elections this fall in the AfD's eastern German strongholds of Saxony-Anhalt and Mecklenburg-Western Pomerania.

AVIATION

AIR FRANCE-KLM TAKES AIM AT TAP: Air France-KLM reiterated Thursday its determination to acquire a stake in TAP Air Portugal, the state-owned flag carrier set to be privatized this year. The Franco-Dutch group, which is still awaiting European Commission approval to increase its stake in SAS Scandinavian Airlines from 19.9 percent to 60.5 percent, is competing against Lufthansa for control of the Portuguese carrier.

Reassuring Lisbon: "It's a different situation than for SAS where we first took a minority stake," said Steven Zaat, Air France-KLM's CFO, during the group's quarterly results press conference. In the TAP bid, "we talk about a stake between 45 to close to 50 percent ... we will work completely in cooperation with TAP to develop all the synergies which are there," Zaat added, seeking to reassure Lisbon that decisions on the network, cargo operations, loyalty programs and maintenance would be taken jointly.

Why it matters: Zaat said Air France-KLM would invest in a maintenance facility in Portugal, something Lufthansa has also pledged to do.

Communication matters: According to Andrew Lobbenberg, Barclays' head of European transport equity research, the Franco-Dutch group played to Lufthansa's weaknesses by "highlighting AF-KLM's strong track record of industrial relations", something he said was weaker with Lufthansa. He also said that Air France-KLM underlined the role that TAP would play as the group's Southern European hub, while Lufthansa already has Italy's ITA. Lufthansa is also centralizing the operations of its subsidiaries, which might be less attractive for the Portuguese government. While Lobbenberg cautioned that the

Portuguese government would not decide on the basis of press releases alone, the statements “do highlight the areas where AF-KLM appears better positioned than Lufthansa.”

Well done on ETS: Asked about the Commission’s recent proposal to review the Emissions Trading System, Air France-KLM CEO Ben Smith said he was “somewhat pleased to see that the obligation for member states to allocate at least 50 percent of ETS revenues to the decarbonization of ETS sectors gets put in place, so that’s positive.” He added that he would like the obligation increased to 100 percent.

Hitting the Gulf: Smith said the group still had to assess the impact of extending the ETS to EU departures bound for destinations within 5,000 kilometers of Frankfurt Airport. But the measure “does somewhat improve the level playing field for our group … This is just a small, potentially small improvement … to cover some of our biggest competitors in the Gulf region.”

CARS

EU’S BATTERY RECYCLING LEAK: Europe is exporting at least 60 percent of the “black mass” recovered from used electric vehicle batteries, risking a shortage of critical raw materials just as Brussels tries to build a domestic battery industry, according to a new Transport & Environment analysis .

A growing problem: T&E estimates at least 27,000 metric tons of black mass — the intermediate recycling material containing lithium, nickel, cobalt and graphite — leaves the EU every year, representing recoverable battery materials from roughly 225,000 electric vehicles worth around €150 million. Much of it is shipped first to South Korea before ultimately reaching China, which already controls about 94 percent of global battery material recovery capacity.

The warning: As more EVs reach the end of their lives, T&E estimates exports could rise to at least 200,000 metric tons a year by 2030, equivalent to the recoverable battery materials from nearly 1.7 million cars. Without intervention, the NGO argued that Europe risks losing valuable feedstock needed to establish a competitive domestic recycling industry.

Europe in focus: The NGO is urging the Commission to use the upcoming Circular Economy Act to curb exports of recyclable materials unless they are processed by EU facilities abroad or clearly benefit the European battery value chain. “It is a make-or-break moment for the EU’s recycling industry,” said T&E’s supply chains policy manager Emily Ritchey, warning that Europe remains heavily dependent on imported critical raw materials while allowing valuable battery materials to leave the bloc.

The bigger picture: T&E argues Europe has a rare competitive advantage: unlike lithium or cobalt mining, it will increasingly generate its own supply of end-of-life batteries as EV sales mature. The question, it says, is whether those critical raw materials will underpin a European recycling industry — or fuel China’s instead.

RAIL

SCARING OFF BEIJING: Three years after coming into force, the EU’s Foreign Subsidies Regulation is increasingly being credited with deterring Chinese state-backed companies from bidding for strategic public contracts — with the rail sector emerging as one of its clearest early test cases.

China backs away: Former industry chief Thierry Breton declared an early victory in 2024 when Chinese rolling stock giant CRRC withdrew from a Bulgarian rail tender. Lawyers say that was not an isolated case, with several other Chinese companies quietly dropping out of procurement procedures before

Brussels had to intervene.

Lisbon precedent: The Commission has also put CRRC through a full Foreign Subsidies Regulation investigation over its bid for Lisbon's metro rolling stock contract, ultimately imposing conditions that led to the award going to Poland's Pesa Bydgoszcz earlier this year. The case has become a key example of how Brussels is using the FSR to police competition in Europe's rail supply chain.

Our colleague Francesca Micheletti has more.

A broader push: The experience echoes the rail industry's wider campaign to shield strategic rail technologies from subsidized foreign competition. During the negotiations on the recently proposed Public Procurement Act, rail manufacturers strongly argued that EU-funded projects should primarily benefit European suppliers and called for high-risk non-EU vendors to be excluded from critical technologies such as signaling, citing both technological sovereignty and military mobility.

PIT STOPS

French-American-Italian automaker Stellantis reported its half-year financials on Thursday, with net revenue up 10 percent year-over-year to €81.6 billion.

Headlines

Here's a recap of yesterday's news, along with Pro articles and alerts from overnight.

China made Germany's car giants. Now it's helping break them.

Germany's politicians are worried about blowback from the car industry's troubles.

By Jordyn Dahl · Jul 30, 2026, 07:31 pm Europe/Brussels CEST

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